

FORWARD DEPLOYED AI ENGINEER GUIDE

Cracking the Forward Deployed AI Engineer Interview

Roadmap, System Design, Case Studies & Mock Interviews
for FDE Roles in 2026

A practical interview-prep handbook for builders who ship AI systems in the field



Cracking the Forward Deployed AI Engineer Interview — Roadmap, System Design, Case Studies & Mock Interviews for FDE Roles in 2026.

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Methodology disclosure. Market data in this book draws on public salary aggregators (Levels.fyi, Glassdoor), public job listings, public conference talks, and the author's own engagement experience. Where a specific number is presented, the methodology section in the front matter explains how to validate it. Time-sensitive figures are dated, sourced, or framed as illustrative rather than market fact.

Anonymized examples. Customer scenarios in this book are composites of patterns the author has observed across multiple engagements. Specific customers, individuals, and identifying details are not used.

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First Edition — 2026.

*For every engineer who chose the harder seat —
the one that faces the customer.*



This Book vs. Generic AI Engineering Books

Dimension	Generic AI Engineering Book	This Book
Audience	“Anyone interested in AI”	FDE / Applied AI / Customer Engineer / Solutions Architect candidates
Job role focus	Building AI products in general	The specific seat that touches customers, code, and product
Interview prep	Generic LeetCode + ML questions	Five-round FDE loop with weak/strong/staff answer tiers
System design	Tutorial-style overviews	Reference architectures with tradeoff tables and failure modes
Customer skills	Often missing entirely	Discovery scripts, stakeholder maps, escalation patterns
Case studies	Vendor-friendly happy paths	Composite engagements with messy reality and lessons learned
Templates	A handful, sometimes	Fourteen artifacts you actually copy and edit
Market data	Asserted as fact	Sourced, dated, or paired with a validation playbook
Update cadence	Static	Revised in dated editions as the market changes

If the differentiation above does not match what you need, this is not the book for you, and I would rather you know that on page seven than page two hundred.

How to Use This Book

You can read this book three ways.

Cover to cover. If you are early in your FDE journey, follow the chapters in order. Each Part builds on the previous one.

Goal-driven. If you have an interview next week, jump to Parts III and IV, then Part VI. If you just landed the role, skip directly to Part VII. Cross-references will pull you back to whatever foundation you need.

Reference-style. The case studies (Part V), reference architectures (Ch. 41), and appendices are designed to be re-read months after the main chapters click.

Insider Tip

The exercises, mocks, and templates only work if you do them. Block ninety minutes a week. Show up. Compounding does the rest.

30 / 60 / 90-Day Reading Tracks

30-Day Sprint — Interview Imminent. Days 1–7: Part I + Ch. 11. Days 8–14: Ch. 13–15. Days 15–21: Part VI + two mocks from Part IV. Days 22–30: Behavioral, negotiation, dry runs.

60-Day Build — Skill Ramp. Add Part II (Ch. 4–7) to the front of the 30-day sprint. Build one Showcase Project from Ch. 12 in parallel.

90-Day Career Reset — New to AI Engineering. Full Part II first, then a Showcase Project, then Part III, then Part IV mocks, then Part V case studies, then Part VI. Save Part VII for week 12.



Market Data Methodology

This book makes claims about FDE compensation, hiring volume, and which companies hire which way. Those claims have a methodology behind them, and you should know what it is before you trust them.

What I draw on

- **Public salary aggregators.** Levels.fyi, Glassdoor, Blind. These have selection bias (over-represent senior, US-based, high-comp candidates) but they are the most current open dataset.
- **Public job listings.** Greenhouse, Lever, and direct company career pages. Useful for ranges that companies disclose by law (CA, CO, NY, WA, IL).
- **Public conference talks and engineering blog posts.** Mostly for technical claims about architectures, not compensation.
- **The author's own observations** from engagements, hiring loops, and reader interviews. These are unavoidably anecdotal and are flagged as such.

What I do *not* use

Anonymous Slack/Discord screenshots, recruiter-shared comp ranges I cannot verify, and “a friend at <company> told me” claims. Those things are real, but they are not reproducible by you, so they have no place in a book like this.

How to validate any claim in this book yourself

1. **Compensation.** Cross-check Levels.fyi and the company's most recent public job listings in your region. If both agree within ~15%, the number is probably defensible. If they disagree, trust the listings (legally disclosed) over the aggregator.
2. **Hiring volume.** Search the company's career page for active FDE/Applied/Customer Engineer roles. Cross-check against LinkedIn “Posted in the last 30 days.”
3. **Architectural claims.** Look for an engineering blog post, conference talk, or open-source repo. If the company has not talked about it in public, treat the claim as a pattern, not a fact.
4. **Vendor claims.** Treat marketing benchmarks as a ceiling, not a floor. Run your own benchmark before you bet a customer engagement on someone else's number.

Evidence convention used in this book

- **Dated source** — a public listing, company page, standards document, research paper, or official announcement with an access date.
- *In my experience* — explicitly anecdotal. One practitioner's pattern recognition, not a market truth.

- **Illustrative example** — a realistic but anonymized or hypothetical number used to teach a method, not a quote from a specific company.

Insider Tip

The single most useful career exercise in this book is not a compensation table. It is the habit of validating every market claim — mine, your recruiter's, your friend's — against two independent public sources before you act on it.

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PART I

Understanding the FDE Role

Before we map out skills, salaries, or system design, we need a shared definition. The phrase *Forward Deployed AI Engineer* is used loosely across the industry: at one company it means a senior engineer who shadows customers; at another it means a sales engineer with code commits; at a third it means an applied scientist deployed against a contract. Part I cuts through that ambiguity. By the end of these three chapters you will know what FDE work actually is, where the roles cluster, what the compensation landscape looks like (and how to validate it yourself), and what mindset the people who succeed in the role share.

What Is a Forward Deployed AI Engineer?

Overview

Start here with a durable definition of the FDE role: how it differs from adjacent titles, what the work actually feels like, and how to tell whether a posting is a real FDE role or just wearing the label.

1.1 Origins of the Role

The Forward Deployed Engineer was popularized by Palantir Technologies and later adopted, renamed, and adapted across enterprise AI companies. Palantir's current public role descriptions still capture the core pattern: FDEs work directly with customers, build end-to-end workflows, take those workflows to production, and feed learnings back into the product suite.¹ The original move inverted the default consulting model. Instead of sending a strategy team to produce slides and then handing implementation to someone else, the company put engineers close to the mission and asked them to ship.

Three structural choices made the model work:

- **Outcomes over deliverables.** A working pipeline mattered more than a tightly scoped statement of work. SOWs existed; they were the floor, not the ceiling.
- **High autonomy.** Junior FDEs were trusted to make architectural decisions, push back on customer assumptions, and represent the company in front of senior buyers.

¹Palantir, "Forward Deployed AI Engineer," accessed 2026-05-06.

- **Product feedback loop.** Patterns that worked in one customer environment were generalized into platform features. The FDE became a forward observer for the product team.

The label has since spread. Frontier labs, vertical AI companies, platform vendors, consultancies, and large enterprises all run roles that look like FDE work, sometimes under different names. Chapter 2 covers the market shape; this chapter is about the role definition itself.

1.2 The 2026 Definition

In 2026, an AI-native FDE is the person who closes the gap between “the customer wants AI in production” and “AI is in production, used daily, and saving measurable time or money.” That gap is rarely closed by a slide deck or a marketplace install. It is closed by an engineer who:

- **Diagnoses** the customer problem in business terms and translates it into an AI architecture.
- **Builds** an end-to-end working system: ingestion, retrieval, generation, evaluation, workflow integration, deployment.
- **Embeds** into the customer’s environment for weeks or months.
- **Hardens** the prototype to survive security review, real users, and uptime targets.
- **Hands off or operates** the system, then feeds learnings back to the product team.

This is intentionally messy at the edges. You will write more YAML than you expected, attend more standups than you would like, and explain model risk to a CFO at least once.

***The one-sentence version:** A Forward Deployed AI Engineer is a production engineer embedded close enough to the customer to discover the real workflow, build the system, prove the business value, and carry the learning back into the product.*

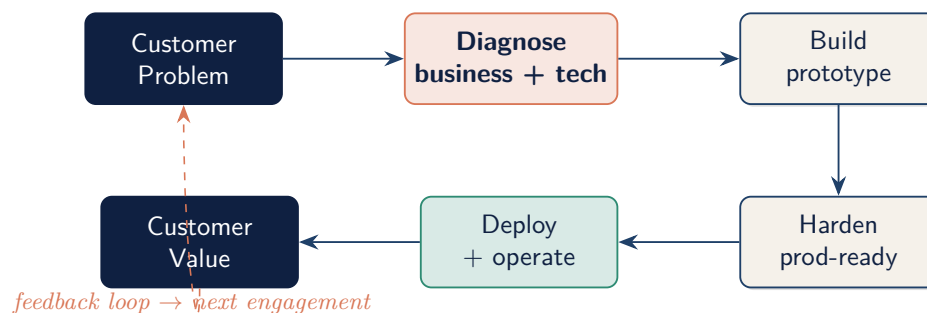


Figure 1.1: The FDE value loop. The arrow from customer value back to customer problem is the part most candidates underestimate — it is what compounds across engagements.

1.3 The FDE Contract

The role is easier to understand if you separate the job title from the contract. An FDE is accountable for four surfaces at once:

Surface	What you own	Failure mode
Customer outcome	The workflow gets better in a way the buyer can measure.	Beautiful system, no adoption.
Production system	The code, data path, evals, and deployment survive real usage.	Demo works; production buckles.
Product signal	Reusable patterns make it back to engineering and product.	Every engagement is bespoke forever.
Field narrative	Stakeholders understand progress, risk, tradeoffs, and next steps.	Good work dies in confused communication.

Most adjacent roles own one or two of these surfaces. FDEs are unusual because the business expects one person, or a very small pod, to keep all four in motion.

1.4 What AI Changes

Forward deployed work existed before generative AI. The 2026 version is different because AI systems have a few properties that ordinary SaaS implementations do not:

- **Behavior is probabilistic.** You are not only debugging code paths. You are debugging model behavior, retrieval quality, tool selection, prompt injection, and user expectations.
- **Evaluation is part of the product.** Anthropic’s public FDE posting explicitly calls for production LLM experience with agent development, evaluation frameworks, and deployment at scale.² OpenAI’s FDE postings similarly emphasize production adoption, evaluation-driven feedback loops, and reusable deployment patterns.³
- **The integration boundary is wider.** A useful AI system touches identity, permissions, documents, CRM records, data warehouses, ticket queues, search indexes, and sometimes voice or browser automation.
- **The cost surface is live.** Every token, retrieval call, rerank, tool execution, and GPU minute has a budget implication. You cannot treat inference cost as a back-office concern.
- **Security review starts earlier.** The moment an agent can call tools or see sensitive data, the architecture becomes a security conversation, not only an ML conversation.

That is why the best FDE candidates sound less like “prompt engineers” and more like product-minded systems engineers who understand model behavior.

²Anthropic, “Forward Deployed Engineer, Applied AI,” accessed 2026-05-06.

³OpenAI, “Forward Deployed Engineer - Semiconductor,” accessed 2026-05-06.

1.5 FDE vs. Adjacent Roles — The Confusion Test

These titles bleed into each other. The table below is the comparison I wish someone had put in front of me earlier.

Role	Owns	Primary Output	Customer Contact
ML Engineer	Production model + serving stack	Trained model, pipeline, dashboards	Indirect / via PM
AI Research Engineer	Model quality, novel techniques	Paper, checkpoint, benchmark gain	Minimal
Solutions Engineer / Sales Engineer	Pre-sale technical fit	Demo, RFP response, POC	High, but pre-contract
Customer Engineer (frontier labs)	Post-contract integration	Working integration, expansion	Continuous
Forward Deployed AI Engineer	End-to-end customer outcome	Production system + business value	Continuous, embedded

The confusion test. If a job posting can be fully described using only one of the rows above, it is probably not really an FDE role. True FDE work braids customer engagement, production engineering, and product feedback. Postings that match only one row are usually mis-titled SE, MLE, or CE roles. That is fine — those are good jobs but you should know what you are signing up for.

Insider Tip

Before you accept any FDE-titled interview, ask the recruiter: “Will I write production code that ships to the customer’s environment, talk to the customer’s stakeholders directly, and feed patterns back to the product team?” If any of the three is a no, recalibrate your expectations to the real role.

1.6 The Hybrid Skill Stack

The single most underrated thing about FDE work is that it is not just engineering plus communication. There are three real legs to the stool, and weakness in any one will sink you.

- **Engineering.** You can build the thing. Production code, real systems, useful diagnostics under pressure. This is the floor, not the ceiling.
- **Customer.** You can sit with non-engineers, ask questions that make them feel understood, and hold authority in a room with a CTO and a procurement officer at the same time.
- **Product.** You can decide what to build and what to defer. You see the difference between a workflow that is annoying and a workflow that is broken. You bring those signals back to the product team without sounding like a salesperson.

The interview loop tests all three, weighted differently by company. Frontier labs lean engineering plus product. Platform companies lean engineering plus customer. Vertical AI companies lean customer plus product. Use this to decide which loops to prioritize.

1.7 Artifacts You Are Expected to Produce

Strong FDEs do not leave only code behind. They leave artifacts that let the customer, the home team, and the next FDE understand what happened.

- **Discovery brief.** Workflow map, stakeholders, pain points, current metrics, target metric, constraints.
- **Technical design.** Architecture, data flows, model choices, eval plan, security assumptions, rollout plan.
- **Evaluation report.** Golden set, offline metrics, failure taxonomy, regression gates, examples of acceptable and unacceptable outputs.
- **Production runbook.** How to deploy, rollback, inspect traces, rotate credentials, pause tool access, and escalate incidents.
- **Field notes for product.** What the customer asked for three times, what the platform made hard, what should become a reusable feature.

If you want to prepare for the job before you have the job, build these artifacts for your portfolio projects. A repo with a live demo is good. A repo with a live demo, eval report, runbook, and customer-style design memo reads like an FDE portfolio.

1.8 A Realistic Week in the Role

Engagement rhythms vary, but a deployed FDE's week typically blends three modes:

- **Customer-facing time (30–40%).** Standups, design reviews, debugging sessions, executive readouts. Calendar-heavy. Communication-heavy.
- **Engineering time (40–50%).** Code, evals, design docs, infrastructure. The work that actually ships. This time is precious; protect it.
- **Internal sync (15–20%).** Your home team. Product feedback, account strategy, mentoring, cross-engagement learnings.

If that mix energizes you, you are wired for this role. If it sounds exhausting, that is also useful information — some excellent engineers are happier in pure ML, applied research, or platform engineering roles.

From the Field

A realistic FDE week has context-switching debt. Monday morning may be a customer exec readout, Monday afternoon a retrieval bug, Tuesday a security questionnaire, Wednesday a product feedback review, Thursday a live demo, and Friday a written reset of scope. The job rewards people who can switch contexts without losing the thread.

1.9 Senior / Staff-Level Expectations

The role ladder is real but the inflection points are unusually clear in FDE work:

Level	What changes
Junior / Associate FDE	Owns components under guidance. Strong individual contributor; minimal direct customer ownership.
FDE	Owns a workstream end to end. Builds, ships, communicates.
Senior FDE	Owns an engagement. Sets technical direction. Coaches juniors. Detects when scope is drifting and re-scopes in writing.
Staff FDE	Owns multiple engagements or a strategic account. Bridges product and field. Ships internal tooling other FDEs reuse. Names the unstated assumption everyone else has been making.
Principal / Lead	Owns a vertical, region, or flagship customer. Defines patterns the rest of the org reuses. Hires.
Director / VP of FDE	Owns the function. Sets pricing, structures engagements, owns the P&L.

The jump from FDE to Senior FDE is about ownership of a full engagement. The jump from Senior to Staff is about leverage — doing things once that ten other engineers reuse.

1.10 The Posting Quality Test

Before you give a company eight hours of interview time, inspect the posting for signals. A high-quality FDE posting usually names:

- **Production ownership.** It says you will ship, deploy, or own systems in production.
- **Direct customer work.** It says you will embed, co-build, travel, or work directly with strategic customers.
- **Product feedback.** It says field patterns become product requirements, reusable modules, reference architectures, or playbooks.
- **Evaluation and reliability.** It names evals, observability, guardrails, or production quality.
- **Travel or location reality.** It tells you whether the job is remote, hybrid, on-site, or travel-heavy.

The weakest postings use FDE as a glamour title for implementation support. They talk about demos, enablement, and “technical partnership” but never say who owns production code, who handles incidents, or whether customer learnings reach product. Treat that as a yellow flag, not an automatic rejection.

1.11 Common Mistakes Newcomers Make

- **Treating the customer as the user research subject.** They are also your product partner and your reference for the next deal. Ask permission before quoting them, and credit them publicly.
- **Coding before listening.** The first two weeks of any engagement should be calendar-heavy, not commit-heavy.
- **Hiding bad news.** The customer will find out. The only question is whether you told them on Tuesday or they discovered it on Friday.
- **Optimizing for the demo, not the workflow.** The demo wins the meeting. The workflow wins the renewal.
- **Assuming the home team has context.** They do not. Write status updates as if every reader is new.
- **Confusing trust with agreement.** Customers trust you more when you can say no clearly, explain why, and offer a path that still gets them value.

Action Checklist

Chapter 1 closing checklist.

- I can describe the FDE role in one sentence without using the word “hybrid.”
- I can name the four adjacent roles and what makes FDE different from each.
- I have written down which level I am aiming for in the next twelve months.
- I have a recruiter-screening question to confirm a role is really FDE.

What to build next. A one-page memo titled “My FDE definition, 2026.” Three paragraphs: how I will describe the role to my next interviewer, how I will describe it to my partner, and how I will describe it to a recruiter. Bring it to Chapter 11.

The 2026 FDE Market Landscape

Overview

This chapter maps the 2026 FDE market: where roles cluster, how compensation is structured, and how to evaluate a posting before you spend time in the loop.

Source note. The role listings and launch announcements below were checked against public pages on **2026-05-06**. Job URLs move quickly. Treat this as a dated market snapshot, not a promise that a posting will still be open when you read it.

2.1 The Market Shift Since 2024

The FDE market widened because enterprise AI adoption hit the hard part: integrating models into real workflows. In 2023, many customers were still asking, “What can we do with LLMs?” By 2026, the better buyers are asking, “Which workflows can we move into production, how do we evaluate them, and who will own the deployment?”

That question created room for three hiring motions at once:

- **Frontier labs built field engineering teams.** OpenAI’s careers page listed multiple FDE, FDE manager, platform engineer, and technical deployment lead roles across U.S., European, and Asia-Pacific cities on 2026-05-06.¹
- **Model and platform companies productized deployment.** Anthropic, Palantir, Salesforce, Mistral, Cohere, Databricks, Glean, and Scale all advertised roles that combine customer work with production AI delivery.

¹OpenAI careers search for “forward deployed engineer,” accessed 2026-05-06.

- **Consultancies launched FDE-shaped practices.** EY announced FDE roles in the UK and Ireland in April 2026, while Accenture announced forward deployed engineering practices with Microsoft and Google Cloud in March and April 2026.²

The common thread is not the title. It is the operating model: engineers close to the customer, production code in scope, deployment patterns fed back into product or practice infrastructure.

2.2 Representative Hiring Snapshot

This is not a ranking. It is a sourced cross-section of public FDE-shaped roles and FDE practice announcements that show how the market is using the title.

Company	Role / signal	What it tells you about the market	Source / Accessed
Anthropic	Forward Deployed Engineer, Applied AI	Embeds with strategic customers; builds production Claude applications, MCP servers, sub-agents, and agent skills; expected travel around 25%.	anthropic.com/careers 2026-05-06
OpenAI	Multiple FDE roles	OpenAI listed FDE roles across general enterprise, government, financial services, semiconductor, and international markets, plus FDE management and platform roles.	openai.com/careers 2026-05-06
Google Cloud	Forward Deployed Engineer, Applied AI	Conversational AI and agentic workflow delivery; RAG, MCP servers, evaluation pipelines, observability, and up to 50% travel.	Tech:NYC / Google listing 2026-05-06
Palantir	Forward Deployed AI Engineer	The original FDE model in modern GenAI form: direct customer work, production workflows, and feedback into AIP.	jobs.lever.co/palantir 2026-05-06
Salesforce	AI Forward Deployed Engineer	Agentforce deployments; hands-on code, data integration, technical leadership, and 25–50% travel.	careers.salesforce.com 2026-05-06
Databricks	AI Engineer — FDE	Customer-facing GenAI team helping customers productionize first-of-their-kind AI applications on the Databricks platform.	Built In / Databricks listing 2026-05-06
Cohere	FDE, Agentic Platform	Enterprise agent deployment around Cohere North, private cloud/on-prem patterns, and 20–40% travel in public postings.	jobs.ashbyhq.com/cohere 2026-05-06
Mistral AI	Technical Lead, Forward Deployed AI Engineer	Applied AI leadership role owning customer delivery, RAG, agentic workflows, fine-tuning, and product feedback.	jobs.lever.co/mistral 2026-05-06
Glean	Founding Forward Deployed Engineer	Strategic-customer product creation: 0-to-1 surfaces, C-suite discovery, and product features that can ship broadly.	greenhouse / gleanwork 2026-05-06
Scale AI	Senior Forward Deployed Data Scientist / Engineer	Data-science-heavy FDE work: evaluation frameworks, operator workflows, decision-support tools, and measurable customer impact.	scale.com/careers 2026-05-06

continued on next page

²EY, “EY launches Forward Deployed Engineer roles to scale AI into production,” 2026-04-28. Accenture and Microsoft FDE practice announcement, 2026-03-18. Accenture and Google Cloud Gemini Enterprise announcement, 2026-04-22.

(Representative hiring snapshot, continued)

Company	Role / signal	What it tells you about the market	Source / Accessed
EY	FDE roles launch	Consulting-market signal: senior AI engineers embedded in client delivery teams to move AI from experiment to production.	ey.com newsroom 2026-05-06
Accenture	Microsoft FDE practice	Large-scale services signal: Accenture and Microsoft announced a forward deployed engineering practice to operationalize AI across the enterprise.	accenture newsroom 2026-05-06
Accenture	Google Cloud Gemini Enterprise program	Another services signal: Accenture and Google Cloud described thousands of AI-skilled engineers, FDEs, and domain experts for agentic transformation.	accenture newsroom 2026-05-06

What is missing from this table. Many vertical-AI companies hire FDE-shaped roles under titles like *Founding Engineer*, *Implementation Engineer*, *Customer Engineer*, *AI Solutions Architect*, *Applied AI Engineer*, or *Technical Deployment Lead*. Search those titles too. The phrase “forward deployed” is useful, but it is not the whole market.

2.3 Skills Extracted From Public Postings

Cross-referencing the responsibilities above, the 2026 market is asking for the following skill clusters. Treat this as the prep checklist behind the role descriptions.

Cluster	What 2026 postings ask for
Programming & engineering	Python is the universal floor; TypeScript, JavaScript, Java, Go, or Apex appear depending on platform. Expect APIs, async jobs, retries, rate limits, clean typed data models, Docker, Git, and production debugging.
LLM / GenAI core	Prompting, RAG, structured outputs, tool calling, fine-tuning when justified, model selection, latency/cost tradeoffs, and failure analysis.
Agentic systems	Multi-agent workflows, MCP servers, tool boundaries, planner-executor loops, human-in-the-loop review, budget caps, kill switches, and audit trails.
Evaluation & observability	Golden sets, regression gates, trace inspection, LLM-as-judge with caution, failure taxonomies, online sampling, dashboards, and written eval reports.
Cloud & data platforms	At least one major cloud; Databricks, Snowflake, BigQuery, Azure AI, AWS Bedrock, Vertex AI, Kubernetes, Terraform, and data warehouse integration depending on employer.
Data & retrieval	SQL, document parsing, chunking, hybrid retrieval, reranking, vector indexes, permission-aware retrieval, schema-on-read, and data quality diagnostics.
Security & compliance	SOC 2 inheritance, HIPAA/BAA, FedRAMP/ATO language, GDPR, SSO/OIDC, RBAC, audit logs, PII/PHI controls, prompt injection, tool security, and secrets handling.
Customer & consulting	Discovery scripts, stakeholder maps, success metrics, SOW literacy, weekly written updates, demo design, executive communication, and pilot-to-production conversion.

The pattern across the listings. The bar in 2026 is not whether you can use one model or one cloud. It is whether you can deploy production-grade AI systems end to end — with evals, observability, guardrails, and a customer relationship strong enough to survive the second engagement.

2.4 Where the FDE Roles Cluster

I find it useful to think of the buyer side of the FDE market in five tiers. The tier shapes the pay, the work, and the daily texture of the job.

Frontier labs. Anthropic, OpenAI, Google DeepMind, and a handful of others. FDE-style roles often go by *Applied AI Engineer*, *Customer Engineer*, or *Deployed Engineer*. The work skews toward bringing the lab’s models into Fortune 500 production. Compensation skews equity-heavy.

Platform companies. Palantir is the originator and still the heaviest user of the FDE term. Scale AI, Cohere, Databricks, and Snowflake have variations. The work skews toward platform integration with a heavy data-engineering tail.

Vertical AI companies. Glean, Writer, Harvey, Hippocratic AI, Sierra, and many newer entrants. FDE-style roles are often called *Founding Engineers* or *Implementation Engineers*. The work is closer to product, with customer engagements as the forcing function.

Boutique consultancies and AI-native services firms. BCG X, Slalom, smaller specialists. Roles look like FDE work but with stronger billable-hours pressure and a thinner product feedback loop.

Enterprise internal teams. Banks, insurers, hospital systems, defense primes. They are hiring FDE-style internal engineers to deploy AI inside their own walls. Pay is often surprisingly competitive once you factor in stability and benefits.

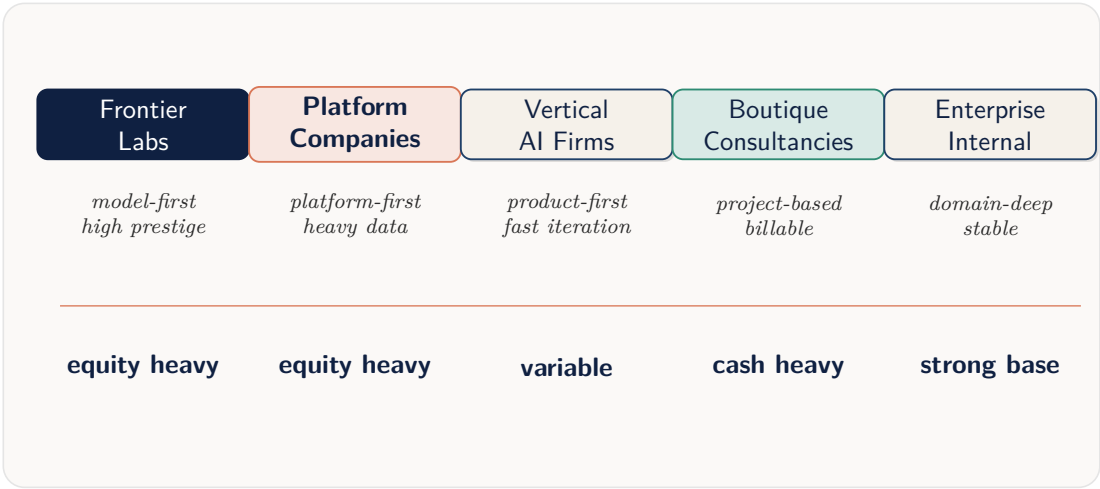


Figure 2.1: The five buyer tiers of FDE talent and how their offers tend to be structured. This is a market model synthesized from the public postings and practice announcements cited in this chapter; validate any specific offer against the actual company listing.

2.5 Industry Verticals

Independent of buyer tier, the verticals that drive FDE demand:

- **Defense and intelligence.** Where Palantir built its reputation. Security clearances narrow the candidate pool you compete against.
- **Financial services.** Banks, insurers, asset managers all have GenAI mandates. Heavy on retrieval, compliance, and document understanding.
- **Healthcare and life sciences.** Clinical decision support, claims, drug discovery. HIPAA and a slower deployment cycle, but high impact.
- **Energy and manufacturing.** Less hype, more substance. Predictive maintenance, knowledge management, complex equipment troubleshooting.
- **Public sector (non-defense).** State and federal civilian agencies. Slower but stable.
- **Enterprise SaaS.** You are an FDE for the customer of a software company. Sales engineering with implementation muscle.

2.6 Compensation — How to Think About Ranges

I am deliberately not opening with a compensation table presented as fact. Compensation is too noisy, too regional, and too time-sensitive for a published number to be load-bearing for your career. Instead, here is how to build your own range for any specific role.

- 1. Pull the public listing.** Many U.S. states require salary range disclosure. Read the listing in the highest-disclosing region the company hires in.
- 2. Cross-check Levels.fyi.** Filter to the same level, region, and company. Note the median and p75. Discount the p99 outliers.
- 3. Add equity context.** For pre-IPO companies, compute the annualized expected value at the last-round valuation. For public companies, compute the four-year vested grant in dollars at current price.
- 4. Add total comp context.** Sign-on, refresh grants, bonus targets. The headline “base” rarely tells the full story.
- 5. Talk to two people.** Ideally one inside the company and one who recently left. Ask about refresh grants and how the bonus actually paid out the last two years.

Public Posting Ranges Observed on 2026-05-06

The table below uses only public posting ranges from the sources linked earlier in this chapter. These are base salary or posted compensation ranges, not guaranteed total compensation.

Company / role	Posted range	Notes
Anthropic FDE, Applied AI	\$200K–\$300K	Annual salary/OTE range in public posting; equity and benefits separate.
OpenAI FDE, Semiconductor	\$162K–\$302K + equity	Public posting range for San Francisco role; vertical-specific and seniority-sensitive.
Palantir Forward Deployed AI Engineer	\$135K–\$200K	Base salary estimate; posting notes RSUs, sign-on, and incentives may be additional.
Google Cloud FDE, Applied AI	\$127K–\$183K + bonus/equity	Public listing range for one mid-level U.S. posting; other levels/locations show different ranges.
Salesforce AI FDE, Senior/Lead/Principal	\$117.2K–\$313.7K	Broad U.S. base range across levels and locations.
Glean Founding FDE	\$160K–\$270K	Broad annual range across levels; equity and variable compensation may apply.
Scale AI Senior Forward Deployed DS/Engineer	\$167.2K–\$209K	Base range for SF, New York, and Seattle posting; equity may apply.
Databricks AI Engineer — FDE	\$161.3K–\$225.8K	Public job-board mirror for U.S. AI FDE posting; verify against Databricks careers before quoting.

Worked example. Suppose you are evaluating a Senior FDE-equivalent role at a private vertical AI company. The public listing gives \$200K–\$260K base, equity is described as “meaningful,” and the recruiter says total compensation is “competitive with frontier labs.” Do not negotiate off that sentence. Ask for the annualized equity value, vesting schedule, latest 409A or share price, refresh policy, and whether there is a tender program. Then compare the cash component against public ranges above and discount the equity for liquidity risk.

Watch Out

The largest variable in any FDE compensation conversation is private-company equity. A senior FDE at a top lab in 2026 may have more compensation in unvested equity than the prior decade of their career combined but that number is paper until it is liquid. Build a model. Discount for the probability of liquidity in the next four years. Do not confuse the headline with the dollar.

2.7 Geography and Remote Realities

The public postings reviewed for this chapter cluster around San Francisco / Bay Area, New York, Seattle, Washington DC, Chicago, Austin, Atlanta, London, Dublin, Munich, Paris, Toronto, Singapore, Tokyo, Sydney, and Seoul. Do not quote a percentage without re-running the search; the live market changes too quickly.

Remote-first FDE roles exist, but true FDE work often skews hybrid or travel-heavy because the role's premise involves sitting near the customer at moments of ambiguity. If you are interviewing remote, look for two markers: explicit travel expectations and a written engagement model. If neither shows up in the loop, the role may quietly drift back to the office post-offer.

2.8 The Generative AI Shift

The defining change since 2023 is that the work has compressed in time and expanded in scope. What used to be a six-month custom build is now often a six-week prototype. What used to be a three-person engagement is now sometimes one person scaled by the platform.

The implication for the skill ladder: a junior FDE in 2026 is expected to ship things solo that a senior FDE was expected to ship with a team in 2021. Daunting, but the leverage is real — an FDE in 2026 ships outcomes that used to require a department.

2.9 Future Outlook (with Caveats)

Three trends I think will shape FDE demand through 2027. Each one is a hypothesis worth pressure-testing, not a forecast.

- **Agents are crossing into production.** As multi-step, tool-using systems become reliable enough to deploy, FDE work shifts from RAG-heavy to agent-heavy. The skill that compounds is evaluation: can you tell when an agent is actually doing the job versus performing it convincingly?
- **On-prem and air-gapped deployments are surging.** Regulated industries are demanding control over weights and data. FDEs who can deploy and operate self-hosted LLM stacks are scarce.

- **The line between FDE and Founding Engineer is blurring.** Many of the best FDEs are using their customer reps to start vertical AI companies. If that is your trajectory, this book is also designed to load you up for it.
- **Services firms are legitimizing the model.** When EY and Accenture put the FDE language into public announcements, it signals that buyers now understand the category. That is good for candidate demand, but it also means you must inspect whether a role has a real product feedback loop or is primarily consulting delivery.

2.10 Evaluating a Specific FDE Posting

Action Checklist

Posting evaluation checklist.

- Title resolves to: production code shipping + direct customer contact + product feedback loop.
- Travel expectation is in writing.
- Engagement model is described (length, structure, hand-off).
- Compensation range is disclosed (or recruiter will share before final round).
- Loop structure is shareable on request.
- Public engineering blog exists — evidence of how the team thinks.
- At least one current employee is willing to take a 20-minute call.

If a posting fails three or more of the above, deprioritize it relative to postings that pass them. Your time pipeline is a finite resource.

What to build next. A spreadsheet of every FDE-titled role you can find this week, scored against the checklist above. Sort descending. Apply to the top six.